

Remembering Bighorn
Modern-day Sioux gather at the Little Bighorn river, Montana, *(above)* for a re-enactment of the famous battle in 1876 in which Sioux and Cheyenne warriors annihilated part of General Custer's 7th cavalry. Steel knives *(right)* were traded with the Sioux by European settlers, usually in return for furs. They were far more effective than the Sioux's traditional stone implements.

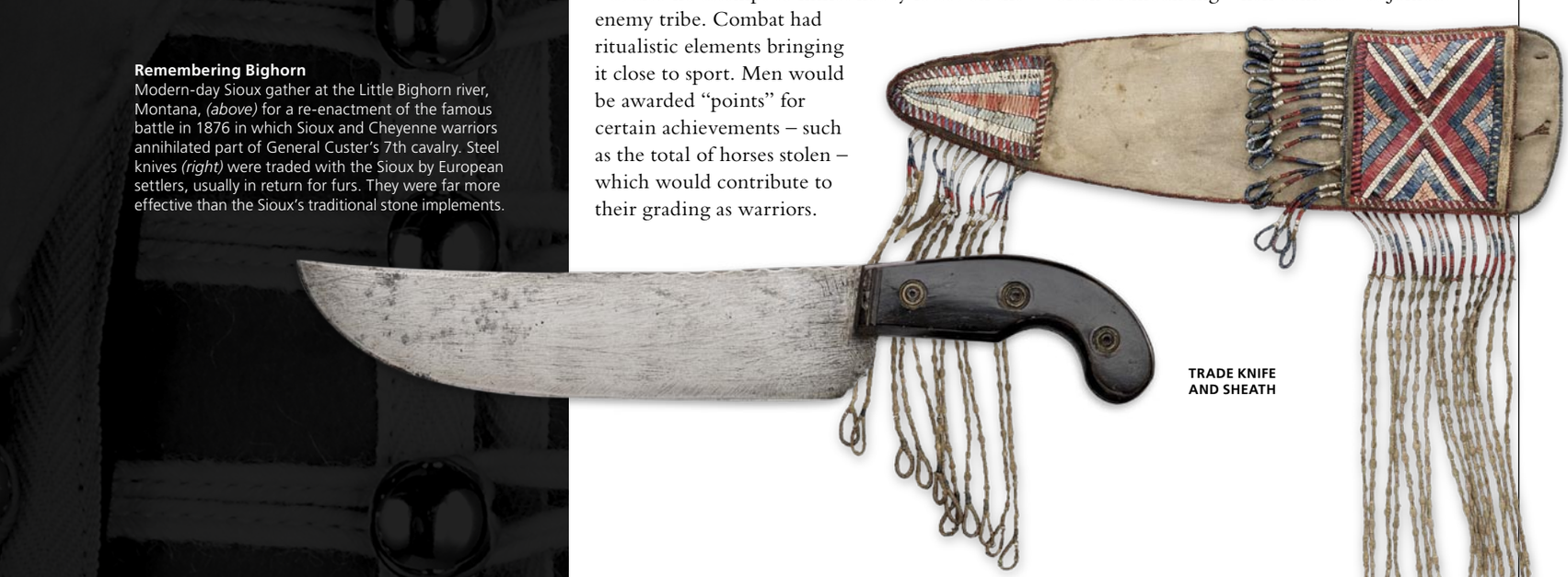
From the 1860s to the 1880s the Sioux tribes, along with other nomadic buffalo-hunting Plains Indians such as the Cheyenne and the Arapaho, fought a guerrilla war against the US Army in a last-ditch attempt to block settler encroachment on their hunting grounds. They evolved a form of warfare based on their skills as horsemen, hunters, and raiders. Although they had no chance of ultimate success, given the willpower and resources of their opponents, they proved superior in combat on their own terms.

For the men of the Sioux nations, fighting was a way of life. Warfare was central to the social and economic existence of the tribe. But it was also crucial to personal ambition, for it was through combat that an individual warrior could prove his courage and martial skills, and thus hope to rise in the warrior hierarchy of his society. The practical objectives of warfare were many and various. Tribes raided their neighbours to steal horses or to take women and children captives – thus increasing their own population. They fought for control of hunting grounds and for control of trade. But warfare was also likely to be provoked by some insult or misdeed that the honour of the tribe required be avenged.

The Plains Indians' traditional form of warfare was what Europeans once called "the skulking way of war". It consisted of raids and ambushes carried out by stealth. Raiding parties typically numbering no more than 30 or 40 warriors would embark on a combat mission, usually returning after a single fight with the chosen enemy. Fighting was generally not very destructive. Minimizing one's own casualties was an important principle, for Plains Indian peoples had low birth rates and the lives of their warriors were a precious resource. Mostly there was also no attempt to inflict heavy losses on the enemy tribe. Combat had ritualistic elements bringing it close to sport. Men would be awarded "points" for certain achievements – such as the total of horses stolen – which would contribute to their grading as warriors. A Sioux warrior would get more points for the courageous act of touching an enemy with a "coup stick" – the willow rod used for this ritual strike – than for killing one with an arrow at a distance. Yet it must not be imagined that Sioux warfare was a bloodless game. The scalping of dead enemies was a well-established practice, apparently designed to prevent the fallen warrior from entering the afterlife, where he might have pursued revenge against his killer. This practice was encouraged when white traders proved ready to pay good money for scalps as curios.

TRADITION AND INNOVATION

Adopted as recently as the 17th century, after being introduced to the Americas by Spanish invaders, horses were the Sioux's most prized possessions, vital for both hunting and war. Mostly small, thin, hardy, and fast-moving, they were accumulated by successful tribes in large numbers. Every warrior needed second-string ponies for travelling distances and a specially-prized mount as his warhorse. The Sioux were exceptional horsemen, capable of tricks such as hanging over one side of a galloping horse to keep its body between them and an enemy. But they did not always fight on horseback, more often dismounting when combat was joined.



TRADE KNIFE AND SHEATH